‘[T]he promised new swadeshi steamship’[84] arrived in Tuticorin from Colombo on 16/17 April with a triumphant VOC on board.[85] The police observation that ‘[t]here was no disturbance at all’ can be read as general jubilation in the town without any violent incidents.[86] However, there was much that did not catch the public eye. Fifteen months later, VOC described the circumstances in court:

> I was due at Tuticorin, on 16 May [sic.] 1907.[87] Then also certain Police and Military men were sent for and kept ready at Tuticorin, and I was informed that some arrangements were going to cause some disturbance if any procession was celebrated on my arrival and to charge me as one of the rioters. So, I avoided the procession or any public reception. The District Magistrate Mr Coleridge, who was there anticipating some breach of peace, came to me and had a long talk with me in my office. Then also the arrival of three Japanese Warships was mentioned to me by Mr Coleridge and an Iyengar Deputy Superintendent of Police who was with him. I told the District Magistrate all that the British India Steam Navigation Co were doing since our service started and satisfied him that there was nothing to apprehend a breach of the peace. At once he ordered the Reserve Police and Military to return to their places. As soon as I arrived at Tuticorin I was told Mr Waller [the head assistant collector stationed in Tuticorin], had issued an order to the Inspector of Police that if I deliver any speech near any public street after my return from Bombay, I should be charged with obstructing the public way. I informed Mr Coleridge and he at once withdrew that order also and asked Mr Waller to write to me that he had no objection to my speaking in public places. He wrote to me accordingly.[88]

Clearly, VOC, while asserting his rights, was trying to avoid any confrontation that could lead to a conflict and possibly harm SSNCo.

Two days after arriving in Tuticorin, the *Gallia* sailed to Colombo.[89] As VOC was due to speak on Swadeshi on 21 April at the invitation of the South Indian Association at Colombo, he also embarked on the *Gallia*.[90]

With the arrival of the *Gallia* the Tuticorin–Colombo Swadeshi service resumed after a lapse of several months ‘due to various causes’, as the *Bande Mataram* reported. (The prime cause was of course the non-availability of any steamer with the Swadeshi company.) The *Gallia* had required a thorough overhaul in the Colombo docks by Hudson and Company. Surveys had been made by Captain J.A. Legge, master-attendant, G.H.M. Hyde, assistant factory engineer and N. Boack, engineer and